

The Nomadic Ear: Collective Field Recording and Non-identitarian Listening in Urban Space

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ABSTRACT | This paper explores the practice of field recording as a form of psychogeographical *dérive* in contemporary urban environments, outlining a conceptual framework for the collective and relational dimensions of listening. It is argued that collective sound *dérive* constitutes an epistemic and political tool for reading urban acoustic territories and for generating non-identitarian sound communities: forms of belonging founded on the contingent and dialogic experience of the field, rather than on pre-existing identity. When practised collectively, environmental recording serves as a device for the shared production of meaning, capable of rendering the dominant acoustic order visible and challenging it. While existing literature on sonic artistic practices in urban space focuses predominantly on sound installation and soundscape design, this paper serves as a premise for broader research into musical improvisation as a situated and dialogic practice of intervention in urban space.

KEYWORDS: *Psychogeography, Field recording, Collective listening, Urban space, Improvisation*

1. SOUND AS A SUBJECT OF RESEARCH

Since the early 2000s, there has been a growing interest within academia in the role of sound and listening in human activity and urban environments, to the extent that Tom McEnaney has termed this shift ‘sonic turn’ [1].

However, as early as the mid-20th century, various artistic movements had turned their attention to non-musical sound and its effects on the human body. In particular, reference is made here to the Situationist movement and its practices of *dérive* and psychogeography. The Situationists, walking without a specific destination and allowing themselves to be guided by sounds, smells, or other stimuli provided by the urban environment, theorised the *dérive* as a collective practice for redefining the city through subjective experience. The *dérive* is the main technique of psychogeographical exploration, which analyses the effects that urban space has on the human psyche.

According to Stefan Winter, these methodologies have now evolved into useful procedures for artistic research to help us understand the city’s soft infrastructure in relation to its hard infrastructure [2].

2. SONIC DRIFT: FROM SOLITARY LISTENING TO COLLECTIVE PRACTICE

Recent artistic and research practices show how psychogeographical drift has already been translated into work with sound, whilst also allowing us to identify a spectrum ranging from individual listening to increasingly collective forms.

Budhaditya Chattopadhyay develops a nomadic mode of listening to the environment [3] and uses the audio recordings of his drifts to inform the composition of musical works. Instead, Katt Hernandez proposes ‘aural transposition’ as a psychogeographical pilgrimage through sound, using field recording and instrumental practice to recreate real or imagined places and bring forth phantom traces of memory [4]. In these two examples, the act of drifting is solitary: the community is reached in mediated ways.

During a sonic urbanism seminar convened in Cape Town by Bradley Rink and other academics [5], listening, by contrast, is practised collectively. In the tradition of the Situationists, meanings emerge through negotiation between different listeners, each bringing a distinct bodily perspective and personal history. Field recording here is, at the very moment of its production, a device for community building. The recording becomes a relational protocol.

The aim here is to articulate nomadic listening as a constitutively collective practice: a shared crossing of urban space that can generate non-identitarian sound communities.

Following Brandon LaBelle’s notion of ‘unlikely publics’ [6], these are communities in motion formed by the contingent and dialogic experience of the field itself. The relevant sediment is deposited in the listening subjects themselves. Drawing on Stavros Stavrides’s notion of the threshold subject, participation in collective sonic drift transforms those who pass through it by rendering them more permeable to future encounters with contested acoustic space [7]. However, in order to leave lasting traces beyond the individual, the intervention must generate a shared discussion among participants, city dwellers, and stakeholders, one capable of orienting the collective imagination toward alternative configurations of public space [8].

3. EMBODIED LISTENING AND CONTESTED SPACE

Sound recording has found a specific place within urban geography and ethnography [9]: this practice provides the means to analyse interactions and minute details, both verbal and non-verbal, that would go unnoticed in other types of urban research, helping to reveal power relations within cities. Beyond its documentary function, however, Michael Gallagher argues that field recording carries a performative value: it is “an event taking place here and now, as well as a record of another time and place” [10, p. 561], hybridising the present space with acoustic traces of another situation.

Furthermore, to understand why certain deviations carry political significance, we must first ask who has designed the acoustic order we encounter. Rowland Atkinson introduces the concept of ‘sonic ecology’ (building on R. Murray Schafer’s earlier work on soundscape) to explain that this order is not random, but is often designed to guide, invite, or exclude citizens through a precise spatial and temporal organisation of sounds [11]. This order serves as a mechanism of social filtering, in which noise management

and the use of functional music (muzak) demarcate acoustic territories designed to encourage consumption and marginalise social groups deemed out of place.

Therefore, the practice of collective field recording takes on a political dimension: to record is already to take a stand against what the dominant acoustic order prefers to leave unnoticed. Collective drifting does not simply multiply the listening points: it produces a situated and public negotiation of what is worthy of being recorded, of what disturbs, of what one prefers to ignore.

4. TOWARDS A METHOD

Existing literature on sonic artistic practices in urban space focuses predominantly on sonorisation practices and soundscape design. Bruce Odland and Sam Auinger transform urban noise into shared environments through large-scale public installations to encourage community engagement [12]. At the same time, Nadine Schütz proposes experimental fieldwork methods to integrate sound as a design quality in public space, challenging the reduction of acoustic planning to mere noise mitigation [13].

Musical improvisation as a form of dialogic intervention in urban space remains comparatively underexplored, and it is precisely what the broader research project, emerging from the notion of non-identitarian sound community, aims to address.

To translate this framework into research practice, an evaluative instrument is required that can trace what persists after the experience. Nicola Di Croce's threefold protocol, developed through a participatory sound project in Montréal's Quartier des Spectacles, offers a methodical precedent: sensory-based research before the intervention, implementation informed by that research, and evaluation of its long-term impacts, through qualitative and participatory methods [8, p. 168]. Following this structure, the research will develop a questionnaire to be administered at two distinct moments.

The first set of questions follows the field recording session: participants (the improvising musicians themselves) will be asked to list five to ten words or short concepts describing what they experienced during the drift; whether recording collectively, compared to listening alone, changed what they paid attention to; and whether they expect, six months from now, to hear the traversed space, or similar spaces, differently. The second set follows the improvisation session: whether the collective listening changed how participants related to the other performers; to what extent they felt the space was determining their choices; and which sounds from the drift resurfaced, not as conscious quotation, but as gesture, texture, or impulse.

A workshop with professional improvising musicians, to be held next year, will serve as the first testing ground. The questionnaire will be refined through this first workshop and expanded in a follow-up planned after six months to trace whether and how the sonic memory of the drift migrates into other performative contexts over time.

The present design focuses on the improvising musicians as its primary subjects; a future expansion may extend the questionnaire to non-performing listeners.

5. CONCLUSIONS

This paper serves as a conceptual introduction to a broader research into musical improvisation as a form of temporary and dialogic intervention in the urban space.

Reflective field recording, informed by collective *dérive*, constitutes a sensory-based practice: it trains the group to read the city's atmosphere, to identify its fractures and its acoustic territories. Musical improvisation, understood as a situated and dialogic response to what the space offers and imposes, is the moment of intervention: it acts upon that fabric, traverses it, and calls it into question. The structural link between these two moments is not yet a proven hypothesis. It is the research question that this contribution raises. A first empirical step toward addressing it lies in the structured reflection that follows both the drift and the improvisation session: whether and how the sonic memory of the field migrates into improvisational practice is precisely what the pilot questionnaire is designed to probe.

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